your presence on New Year's Eve, 1965, will be an *eternal* and *immutable* feature of spacetime.

This realization still leads us to some quirky conclusions, but it avoids paradox. For example, you would appear in the spacetime loaf at 11:50 p.m., December 31, 1965, but before that moment there would be no record of your existence. This is strange, but not paradoxical. If a guy saw you pop in at 11:50 p.m. and asked you, with fear in his eyes, where you came from, you could calmly answer, "The future." In this scenario, at least so far, we are not caught in a logical impasse. Where things get more interesting, of course, is if you then try to carry out your mission and keep your parents from meeting. What happens? Well, carefully maintaining the "spacetime block" perspective, we inescapably conclude that you can't succeed. No matter what you do on that fateful New Year's Eve, you'll fail. Keeping your parents apart—while seeming to be within the realm of things you can do—actually amounts to logical gobbledygook. Your parents met at the stroke of midnight. You were there. And you will "always" be there. Each moment just is; it doesn't change. Applying the concept of change to a moment makes as much sense as subjecting a rock to psychoanalysis. Your parents met at the stroke of midnight, December 31, 1965, and *nothing* can change that because their meeting is an immutable, unchangeable event, eternally occupying its spot in spacetime.

In fact, now that you think about it, you remember that sometime in your teens, when you asked your dad what it was like to propose to your mother, he told you that he hadn't planned to propose at all. He had barely met your mother before asking the big question. But about ten minutes before midnight at a New Year's party, he got so freaked by seeing a man pop in from nowhere—a man who claimed to be from the future— that when he met your mother he decided to propose, right on the spot.

The point is that the complete and unchanging set of events in spacetime necessarily fits together into a coherent, self-consistent whole. The universe makes sense. If you time-travel back to December 31, 1965, you are actually fulfilling your own destiny. In the spacetime loaf, there is someone present at 11:50 p.m. on December 31, 1965, who is not there at any earlier time. From the imaginary, outside perspective of